

Chapter 45-1

After Liang Shi dropped out of high school, she worked part-time at a dessert shop.

She probably had a natural talent for cooking. At that time, she not only quickly mastered cake-making techniques but even improved the recipes. For a while, that cake shop was bustling with customers.

When she later left the dessert shop, the owner was quite reluctant to let her go.

After she started acting, she rarely had time to cook for herself, let alone make desserts.

Occasionally when she had free time, baking herself an egg tart¹ was already considered a treat.

The last time she made a mango cake for Ling Dang, it was a small one, and the method was different from this one.

This time, Liang Shi was bringing out her best skills from the bottom of her repertoire.

However, having not done this for so long, Liang Shi was also worried about messing up.

But Xu Qingzhu looked at her with such trust that she could only force herself to maintain composure, pretending to be effortlessly skilled.

Fortunately, she remembered most things.

Cooking was a relaxing process for her—she didn't need to think about anything else, just focus on what was in front of her.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help much, so she stood at the kitchen doorway waiting.

The kitchen was large and semi-open.

Liang Shi moved back and forth at the prep counter, then suddenly exclaimed.

Xu Qingzhu quickly asked, "What's wrong?"

She hurried over to look and found that Liang Shi's shirt was stained with flour.

"I'll help you find an apron," Xu Qingzhu said while reaching up to help brush the flour off her clothes. But what had gotten on the shirt wasn't just dry flour—there was also a bit of wet mixture, and the combination wasn't easy to clean off.

"Don't bother with it," Liang Shi said. "I'll just put it in the washing machine later."

Xu Qingzhu frowned, seemingly determined to deal with that small patch of flour. "Wait a moment."

She turned and went to the living room to get a pack of wet wipes, her slender fingers pinching the wet tissue as she lifted the hem of Liang Shi's shirt with one hand.

Wind quietly slipped in along the shirt's hem, brazenly brushing against her skin.

Xu Qingzhu lowered her head, her hair falling to both sides, revealing her slender, pale neck. The curve of her spine disappeared beneath her solid-colored clothing. When Liang Shi looked down slightly, she inadvertently caught a glimpse of the spring scenery² peeking over the wall.

White, with lace trim.

The bra strap's adjustment buckle was pulled almost to her shoulder, clearly showing how thin she was.

She could even faintly see the shape of her collarbone from the side.

Liang Shi only glanced once before looking away, but when Xu Qingzhu lifted her shirt hem, her pinky finger would unconsciously curl up.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't someone who liked to keep long nails—all her nails were trimmed neat and clean. But she liked nail art, changing to new designs from time to time, though never too bold, mainly sticking to cool, light color schemes.

So at this moment, her fingertip lightly touched the skin of Liang Shi's abdomen.

The sensation of skin touching skin was very distinct. Liang Shi held her breath and sucked in her stomach.

But Xu Qingzhu's fingers were too slender. Even though Liang Shi had pulled in her abdomen to the extreme, there would still be those fleeting, barely-there touches.

Fleeting and elusive touches were the most alluring.

Liang Shi inexplicably felt that this kitchen was a bit small, even the air circulation seemed poor, making it impossible for her to breathe steadily.

Xu Qingzhu kept her eyes lowered, her expression serious. After wiping away that small patch of flour with the wet tissue, she released Liang Shi's shirt hem, but that area was now wet.

Xu Qingzhu looked a bit dejected. "Why don't you go upstairs and change clothes?"

"No need," Liang Shi immediately moved away from her. "It's fine, I'll just put on an apron."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Are you sure you don't need to? That water stain is quite large."

Liang Shi: "..."

There's really no need.

Xu Qingzhu didn't say anything more and took an apron down from the wall to hand to Liang Shi.

Footnotes: ¹ Egg tart: A popular Chinese pastry consisting of a flaky pastry shell filled with sweet egg custard ² Spring scenery: A Chinese euphemism referring to intimate or revealing glimpses of someone's body, derived from classical poetry

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Liang Shi had long arms and could easily tie the strings behind her back, but having just experienced those sensations, her originally nimble fingers now refused to cooperate. Her fingers trembled so much that Xu Qingzhu couldn't bear to watch. "Let me do it."

Without waiting for Liang Shi's response, she stepped forward directly.

And pushed Liang Shi's hands away.

It was clearly a motion tinged with slight disdain, yet Liang Shi licked her lips because of the touch of their fingers.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers were very cool, a different temperature from her own fingertips.

She didn't know if this was an Omega's natural constitution or if it was unique to Xu Qingzhu.

She efficiently helped Liang Shi tie the apron.

Liang Shi finally couldn't help but say, "Go put on another layer of clothing."

"What's wrong?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled. "I'm not cold. Are you cold? If so, I'll help you get your coat."

"I'm not cold, your hands are cold," Liang Shi said, holding her wrist in the air and placing her hand against her neck. "Your hands are frozen red."

"Constitutional issue," Xu Qingzhu shrank back from her own cold hands, tilting her head to glance at her.

This glance carried a hint of playful reproach.

At least, that's what it seemed like to Liang Shi.

Mainly because those light-colored pupils of hers were too easy to create such illusions.

Especially when she smiled.

Liang Shi's heart tightened, and her speech became somewhat clumsy. "Then... then go find a hot water bottle to warm them up. How can you let yourself get frozen by your own hands?"

After saying this, she felt her words might have been a bit harsh, so she quickly added, "You have to work tomorrow. Don't get a fever again like that day. Your workplace needs you."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Her eyes lifted slightly at the corners, those eyes like flowing starlight, instantly spreading through the air, brilliant and dazzling.

Her cool voice was also tinged with a few notes of tenderness due to this warm atmosphere, as she asked carelessly, "Only my workplace needs me?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"I also..." Liang Shi's words were halfway out when she realized she seemed to be flirting with her, and this flirtation carried some indescribable meaning, so she quickly hit the brakes. "Everywhere needs you, so Teacher Xu, don't get sick, okay?"

But Xu Qingzhu didn't let her off the hook. "I also?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"I misspoke," Liang Shi immediately turned around. "I need to start making the cake. You go do your thing."

"It's Sunday, nothing much to be busy with," Xu Qingzhu said, then suddenly placed both hands on Liang Shi's neck.

Her hands were much cooler than Liang Shi had imagined, like ice cubes just taken from the refrigerator.

The cold made Liang Shi shrink back, but she couldn't help frowning. "You call this a constitutional issue? Are you sure you're not sick?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

A few seconds later, Liang Shi quickly apologized, "Sorry, I wasn't insulting you."

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "Teacher Liang, I'm just doing to you what you did to me."

Liang Shi: "... But your hands are really cold."

Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Aren't I finding something to warm them up now?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Alright then.

She was a thing.

No wait, her neck was a thing.

"Sorry," Xu Qingzhu mimicked her tone perfectly, but her cool voice was a few degrees softer than Liang Shi's. "I wasn't insulting you."

Liang Shi: "...!"

Her voice wasn't loud, her tone light and airy, carrying a barely perceptible alluring quality.

It was especially obvious in the quiet environment. Liang Shi swallowed.

Xu Qingzhu withdrew her hands and moved slightly away from her.

Liang Shi finally breathed a sigh of relief.

"Liang Shi," Xu Qingzhu suddenly became serious. "You evaded answering a question today."

Liang Shi: "... Huh?"

"So this is punishment," Xu Qingzhu's voice carried a hint of laughter, but it wasn't a seductive laugh. "I generally don't hold grudges."

Liang Shi: "..."

Yes, you settle scores on the spot.

"I'm used to settling scores on the spot," Xu Qingzhu said. "We're even."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu: "I'm going to find a hot water bottle. You keep busy."

Liang Shi looked confused. "Oh."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly turned back at the doorway. "By the way, don't deliberately make a mess with lots of tools to get back at me. I hold grudges too."

Liang Shi: "..."

She turned back and finally met her smiling eyes, saying helplessly, "How would I dare?"

"There are plenty of things you dare to do," Xu Qingzhu shrugged. "This wouldn't be different."

Liang Shi: "..."

She had the feeling Xu Qingzhu was implying something.

But Xu Qingzhu quickly changed the subject.

She said, "Teacher Liang, your ears are now red enough to drip blood."

Liang Shi: "..."

Please leave someone some dignity!

Chapter 45-3

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Liang Shi's treasured skills weren't forgotten—the eight-inch cake she baked smelled much more sweetly fragrant than the small cake from last time.

Because last time was for Ling Dang to eat, and considering the child's health, Liang Shi hadn't dared put in too much sugar.

But this time Liang Shi used all the right ingredients generously.

She even made her own piping bag at home, spread a light layer of cream on the cake, and then made decorations.

The appearance was even more beautiful than what dessert shops sold.

There was honeydew jam in the refrigerator, which happened to be green, so she used it to draw bamboo.

Bamboo swaying in the wind, complementing the white cream, looked both dynamic and serene.

Although Xu Qingzhu had been convincing herself to accept that this person had a new skill every day, she was still surprised when she saw this cake.

Yes, it was good enough to open a dessert shop with.

The cream was sweet but not cloying, the cake base was fluffy and delicious, the sweetness just right—better than what she'd bought at dessert shops before.

Dinner naturally couldn't consist of just cake, so while waiting for the cake to bake, Liang Shi made nourishing congee.

She put in peanuts, goji berries¹, and walnuts, and while the congee was cooking, she also stir-fried a vegetable dish.

Enough for two people to eat.

And Liang Shi's cooking was very much to Xu Qingzhu's taste.

After eating, Xu Qingzhu was responsible for cleaning up.

But she discovered that Liang Shi had already finished washing all the utensils used for making the cake.

Looking at the cleaned prep counter, she couldn't help but admire Liang Shi's thoughtfulness.

Standing at the sink, she couldn't help but turn back to look at Liang Shi wiping the table.

That thought appeared inappropriately again: Who is she?

—It seemed unimportant.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and turned on the faucet, letting the gentle water flow over her fingers.

It didn't matter who she was—as long as their "roommate" life together was pleasant, that was enough.

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After cleaning up the table, Xu Qingzhu sat on the sofa with Liang Shi to watch a movie.

It was a new release, a blockbuster that had just finished its theatrical run not long ago.

Even Xu Qingzhu, who was a "movie desert²," knew the name of this film: "Chang Bai³."

In recent years, there had been many xianxia⁴-genre TV dramas, but very few movies.

Firstly, the xianxia worldview was vast, making it difficult to tell a complete story within two hours;

Secondly, many scenes required post-production CGI, demanding high standards for both actors and post-production. To hire an excellent post-production team inevitably cost a lot of money, making production costs high.

Most xianxia movies lost money.

How could they compare to the stability of making TV dramas?

But "Chang Bai" was the dark horse that emerged at the box office recently.

When xianxia TV dramas were dominant, a xianxia movie without much backing quietly premiered.

The strongest promotional point was the female lead, Yang Shuyan.

As a veteran actress known for her acting skills and an established movie queen, Yang Shuyan's acting was universally recognized in the industry. She had burst into public view years ago with a film called "Wind Stops," and her explosive acting ability combined with the character's filter earned her a large fanbase.

All the productions she'd been in over the years never disappointed her fans.

Even so, the film production was so poor they couldn't afford any publicity.

For the first two days after release, the box office was dismal, but two days later, a famous film blogger wrote a review of "Chang Bai" with genuine emotion, even voluntarily giving away a hundred movie tickets in a giveaway, swearing to audiences that not going to theaters to see "Chang Bai" was everyone's loss.

So "Chang Bai" became a box office dark horse thanks to word-of-mouth from audiences, with screening times increasing daily.

Xu Qingzhu knew about this film because of Yang Shuyan.

During that period, reports related to this movie frequently appeared online.

Both were quiet while watching the movie.

Liang Shi was busy observing Yang Shuyan's acting skills, while Xu Qingzhu watched for entertainment. She had always been this way—when reading books or watching movies, she never voiced opinions midway. If she truly had deep insights about something, she would write a review after finishing.

What made this film most famous was still Yang Shuyan's red costume.

The blackened female protagonist was a demoness feared by all, but when Yang Shuyan put on the red robes, her presence commanded attention—so cool it was extraordinary, playing a villain character as both righteous and evil, making it impossible for people to hate her.

In the latter half of the movie, every time Yang Shuyan appeared on screen was shocking.

Her makeup and styling were impossibly beautiful, and her acting was indeed remarkable, even better than Zhao Ying by several degrees.

It completely drew people into following her performance.

Liang Shi thought back to seeing Yang Shuyan during the audition that day. Although she was also a cool older sister type, the feeling she gave off was completely different from what she conveyed in the movie.

It even made it impossible to connect her with the person in the film.

All xianxia dramas had grand themes—the fate of nations, all living beings under heaven.

But "Chang Bai" abandoned this approach, focusing everything on personal ideals.

Love and hatred, the fate of all under heaven—none could compare to her personal ideals.

She was someone both righteous and evil.

She didn't abandon the common people, nor did she abandon her lover, but ultimately chose her personal ideals.

When all choices were placed before her, there were only three words—"I want it all."

How domineering!

This kind of dominance, placed in the entertainment industry, would be difficult for anyone to portray to perfection.

But Yang Shuyan pulled it off.

When watching movies, Liang Shi usually put herself in the position of an observer. Because she was studying, she wouldn't put herself in as an audience member, as that made it too easy to get drawn in.

So she always imagined herself as the director, thinking about which shots looked better, which plot points were more moving, whether the script's turning points felt forced.

But unexpectedly, while watching the second half, she found herself caught up in the protagonist's surging emotions along with her.

Yang Shuyan's acting was truly shocking.

Footnotes: ¹ Goji berries: Also known as wolfberries, these are small red berries commonly used in traditional Chinese medicine and cooking, believed to have health benefits ² Movie desert: A Chinese internet slang term for someone who rarely watches movies or is not well-versed in film culture ³ Chang Bai: Likely refers to Changbai Mountain, a significant mountain range on the China-North Korea border, often featured in Chinese mythology and xianxia literature ⁴ Xianxia: A genre of Chinese fantasy fiction featuring immortals, martial arts, and supernatural elements, literally meaning "immortal heroes"

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When the movie ended, there were behind-the-scenes clips, and in those clips Yang Shuyan transformed into a cheerful neighbor-sister type.

Liang Shi watched in amazement.

And Xu Qingzhu, who was usually quiet during movies, couldn't help but say, "She's so beautiful."

Liang Shi: "..."

"What?" Liang Shi suddenly snapped out of her movie-watching state.

Xu Qingzhu said objectively, "I didn't think so much when I saw her photos before, but she's so beautiful in the movie."

Liang Shi: "..."

The bullet comments from that day suddenly came flooding back to her mind—

"Heaven-conquering earth-conquering glamorous villain Alpha X wealthy princess glamorous white lotus¹ Omega!"

And that one image that made everyone who saw it call it absolutely perfect.

Photoshopped with no sense of incongruity.

The two people were only inches apart—cool older sister type X fishing system².

Anyone who saw it would fall into the CP³ fan pit and never climb out.

Liang Shi coughed quietly, putting away all her praise for Yang Shuyan in her heart, pretending to be nonchalant as she said, "Really? I think she's just so-so."

Xu Qingzhu was surprised, "Weren't you also watching with great interest just now?"

"That was because the plot was good." Liang Shi was stubborn: "I was immersed in the storyline."

Xu Qingzhu: "... Is that so?"

She clearly didn't believe it, raising an eyebrow and saying, "Don't tell me you don't think Yang Shuyan is beautiful?"

Liang Shi avoided her gaze that carried a hint of amusement, answering, "She's okay, ordinarily pretty. I think Sister Ying⁴ is more beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue, "As expected, so everyone says Alphas repel each other, right?"

Liang Shi: "... No, she's just ordinary. Her acting is just so-so too."

Yes, not that great.

Although she seemed to be a little bit better than her current self, it was only a little bit.

Given time, she would definitely surpass Yang Shuyan.

Liang Shi used to be very laid-back in the industry. She could maintain good surface relationships with many people precisely because she was laid-back—someone who didn't fight or compete was especially precious in the entire entertainment industry.

If there was a suitable script, she'd take it; if not, she'd rest.

She never used underhanded methods to harm others.

This was the first time a burning competitive spirit had ignited in her heart.

Wasn't it just good acting?

She could do it too.

She was quite good-looking too.

Looking carefully, her features weren't inferior to Yang Shuyan's, and in some small details, she was even slightly better.

Of course, Liang Shi felt a bit guilty saying this now.

So after saying it, she coughed lightly and added with obvious defensiveness, "Really."

Xu Qingzhu glanced over lightly, her eyes seeming to say—I've already seen through everything.

She shrugged, "I didn't say it was fake either."

Then she added, "I haven't seen Sister Ying's performances, so I won't comment. But everyone has different aesthetics. In terms of looks, I still prefer Yang Shuyan's type."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Don't you prefer..." Liang Shi's words got stuck halfway through, then she awkwardly pressed her lips together.

This seemed to be her subconscious competitive spirit at work.

From a legal standpoint, she was her wife.

So... it seemed... she did have a bit of possessiveness.

Living together day and night, many things seemed to be quietly changing without notice.

Liang Shi felt her mindset was getting a bit dangerous.

And Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, her smile carrying a hint of teasing, "Prefer who? You?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She turned her face away, not looking at Xu Qingzhu, her tone carrying a hint of petulance, "That wouldn't be impossible either."

As soon as she said this, she heard Xu Qingzhu's quiet laugh.

Liang Shi: "...?"

Was that mockery?

What was so funny about this?

Liang Shi coughed lightly, pretending to be calm and righteous, "I'm not worse-looking than Yang Shuyan, am I? Last time when I was trending, many people said I was good-looking."

"Really?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised, "I didn't see that. I was busy watching everyone mock Chen Liuying, saying even pulling a random dog from the street would act better than her."

"But Chen Liuying acting badly doesn't mean I act badly too." Liang Shi retorted, "Besides..."

She stopped mid-sentence.

She slowly turned her head, looking at Xu Qingzhu in bewilderment, only to find Xu Qingzhu's face carrying a smile.

...

She casually grabbed a cushion and threw it over, which Xu Qingzhu caught perfectly.

Hugging the cushion, Xu Qingzhu curled up on the sofa, laughing until she shook, her head buried in the cushion, her voice muffled.

"You're insulting people." Liang Shi mumbled in complaint.

Xu Qingzhu laughed until her speech was unclear, "How did you only just realize?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She helplessly leaned back on the sofa, waiting for Xu Qingzhu to finish laughing.

Laughter seemed to be contagious.

Originally she didn't want to laugh, but hearing Xu Qingzhu laugh, she soon started laughing along too.

Footnotes: ¹ White lotus: A Chinese internet term for someone who appears pure and innocent on the surface but is actually scheming, particularly referring to female characters who act helpless to manipulate others ² Fishing system: A Chinese internet slang referring to someone who appears gentle and harmless but is actually calculating or manipulative, like "fishing" for attention or benefits ³ CP: Stands for "couple" or "character pairing," referring to fans who support romantic relationships between fictional characters or real people ⁴ Sister Ying: Refers to Zhao Ying, an actress character mentioned earlier in the story

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Only after Xu Qingzhu had finished laughing did she lift her head, wiping away the tears of laughter with her hand, then said, "Your reaction is really slow enough."

"You were speaking in riddles." Liang Shi said, "Who could react to that?"

Xu Qingzhu rested her hand against her cheek, suddenly asking very seriously, "Do you have any video of the scene you filmed that day?"

Liang Shi shook her head, "No."

"When will it air then?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi still shook her head, "I don't know."

She felt her performance that day wasn't good enough, still far from comparable to Yang Shuyan, so she gave Xu Qingzhu an evasive answer, "My role is just a tiny bit, a small supporting character. The director might feel this segment would bring negative influence to the drama and cut it directly, so don't have expectations. I don't even have expectations."

"How could that be?" Xu Qingzhu said, "Such a controversial scene would definitely be kept to buy trending topics."

Liang Shi: "..."

She understood that well enough.

"At least it's Teacher Liang's first drama." Xu Qingzhu smiled, "You can look forward to it a little."

Liang Shi: "..."

After a long while, she squeezed out, "No expectations, no disappointment."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She threw the cushion back, and Liang Shi caught it.

"Teacher Liang, could you have a little confidence?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "... Alright then."

Then Xu Qingzhu asked, "Did you get the role from the audition last time?"

"Haven't been notified yet." Liang Shi said, "Don't know when the results will come out."

"Should be a sure thing." Xu Qingzhu's voice suddenly became serious, but she looked at Liang Shi very earnestly, "Liang Shi, when you encounter Chen Liuying in the future, don't be polite. What's yours is yours, you can't give up anything, understand?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

"If she tries to steal your roles, then you steal them back double." Xu Qingzhu said, "You absolutely cannot let her suppress you."

"But Chen Liuying is Bai Weiwei's girlfriend. Won't Bai Weiwei cause trouble for you then?" Liang Shi was troubled, "You're already so busy with work, and if you have to worry about interpersonal relationship issues on top of that, I'd feel guilty."

Xu Qingzhu didn't understand, "What would you feel guilty about?"

"Just being busy with work already exhausts you to the point of fever. If you add all these miscellaneous matters, wouldn't you end up in the hospital from exhaustion? As a qualified Alpha wife, I don't want to become your burden..."

Before Liang Shi could finish speaking, Xu Qingzhu threw a cushion at her, "Are you retreating to advance or pushing your luck?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She awkwardly touched the tip of her nose, "Honest words."

"As if." Xu Qingzhu laughed, but quickly restrained her smile, "Don't worry, I've cut ties with Bai Weiwei."

Liang Shi was shocked, "Huh?"

"It's normal, we have different positions now." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "... That's true too."

"But what's your position?" Liang Shi asked in passing.

Xu Qingzhu also answered casually, "Your position."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her heart suddenly skipped.

Seeing her dazed expression, Xu Qingzhu smiled, "As of now, your position is my position."

Xu Qingzhu didn't mention Bai Weiwei wanting Liang Shi to give up the role, just briefly talked about what happened during the day, then went upstairs.

Leaving only Liang Shi alone downstairs in a daze.

Although everything Xu Qingzhu said was normal.

She could always think of another layer of meaning.

But being unconditionally supported by someone was indeed a very secure feeling.

Moreover, that person was Xu Qingzhu.

If it were Sally¹, Liang Shi definitely wouldn't be so surprised.

Because Sally's personality was straightforward—if I like you, I'll unconditionally support you.

But Xu Qingzhu was an extremely calm person. She was smart, rational, and in some ways very difficult to approach and very hard to be classified as "one of her people."

Yet Xu Qingzhu could say such an irrational answer—standing in your position.

Nothing was more heart-stirring than unconditional support.

Liang Shi looked upstairs, where a dim yellow light was still on by her bedroom door.

In this moment, she decided to completely classify Xu Qingzhu as—one of her own people.

Footnotes: ¹ Sally: A character mentioned earlier in the story, presumably one of Liang Shi's friends

Chapter 45-6

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Liang Shi received the notification of her successful audition around ten o'clock at night. She was soaking her feet at the time, casually playing a mobile game.

A text message popped up from the top of the screen.

She tapped to open it—it was from the production staff, notifying her that she had gotten the role.

She immediately took a screenshot to show Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu sent a middle-aged emoji, a pink lotus flower with several sparkling words next to it: "Keep up the good work."

Liang Shi: "..."

Two seconds later, Xu Qingzhu retracted it.

【Xu Qingzhu: Well done!】

Liang Shi hadn't yet recovered from the shock of that middle-aged emoji and only sent a period
【.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Sleep early, good night.】

Liang Shi: 【Mm, sweet dreams!】

Then she shared this news with Zhao Ying, and casually asked when this production would start filming.

Zhao Ying gave a rough timeframe—about half a month—and asked if she had time.

Liang Shi gave a positive answer, then asked Zhao Ying for her address, saying she wanted to send her a peace charm¹.

Zhao Ying: "..."

She was shocked: 【You believe in that stuff?】

Liang Shi: 【Since I already went.】

Zhao Ying: 【One of life's great scams: "Since we came all this way" and "Since we already went."】

Liang Shi: 【Do you want it or not?】

Zhao Ying: 【Haicheng City Changming District Huazhou International Community Building 3 Unit 1 Room 903, 187xxx, for the gentle lovely beautiful girl. bow.jpg】

Liang Shi was amused by her: 【Okay.】

Then she asked where Zhao Xuning was. Zhao Xuning's answer was as cold as ever: 【Hospital.】

A few seconds later— 【Don't come, no beds available.】

Liang Shi: "..."

Completely speechless.jpg

She thought that when she had time, she'd go to the hospital after work to treat Zhao Xuning to a meal as thanks.

She'd received her care many times before, and Liang Shi wasn't the ungrateful type.

After finishing everything, Liang Shi finally lay down in bed.

Bedtime was her time to understand this world—commonly known as internet surfing.

She scrolled through trending topics, nothing particularly noteworthy.

But there was a recent hashtag #Yang Shuyan Universal Divine Beauty#, which when clicked showed Yang Shuyan's nine-grid² beauty photos.

She opened each one and flipped through them.

Found every single one beautiful.

...

Then under this hashtag she discovered one that wasn't so beautiful.

She tapped to save it and sent it to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu: 【Said good night then went to browse Weibo³?】

Liang Shi: 【... Showing you a beauty.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【...】

Liang Shi: 【Without the drama's filter, she seems just so-so.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【...】

Two seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sent a screenshot of her wallpaper.

It was Yang Shuyan in her red costume from "Chang Bai," hailed by fans as "one divine image that conquers all."

Liang Shi: 【... You'll get aesthetic fatigue from looking at it every day.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【?】

Liang Shi: 【Really!】

Actually, Liang Shi had typed three exclamation marks, but before sending she felt she seemed too excited, so she deleted two.

On Xu Qingzhu's end, it kept showing "the other party is typing."

After a moment.

Xu Qingzhu: 【Really?】

Liang Shi: 【Of course!!】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Then why don't I get aesthetic fatigue from looking at you every day and looking in mirrors?】

Liang Shi: "..."

Momentarily speechless.

Xu Qingzhu sent another screenshot.

It was of their chat window.

The contact name at the top read: It's Liang Shi not Liang He⁴.

The chat background was a silhouette.

Under dim lighting, she stood in the kitchen studying the oven intently, slightly bent over, with several strands of long hair falling in front, but you could see most of her profile.

Through Xu Qingzhu's lens, she wasn't overly thin, nor was she fat, but had just the right fullness.

Breasts slightly larger than the average Alpha, buttocks more shapely than the average Alpha.

Even wearing an apron, it didn't diminish the poetry.

The filter was just right, the angle beautiful, full of atmosphere.

It immediately gave one a sense of the warmth of human life.

This image would make people exclaim in admiration even if posted on her old Weibo.

It had to be said, Xu Qingzhu was very good at photography.

For a moment, Liang Shi felt her heart filled with something.

But after two minutes of calming down, she sent: 【Secret photography of me? Hand over the original.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【?】

— 【It was open photography, you just didn't see. As for the original? Why should I give you what I took?】

Liang Shi: 【... Then you're violating my image rights.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【I didn't sell it for money.】

Liang Shi: 【...】

Xu Qingzhu: 【After you become famous, I'll hang it out to sell, should make a small profit.】

Liang Shi: 【...】

After sending two strings of ellipses, she said helplessly: 【Fine, you're right about everything.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【How could that be? Teacher Liang taught me well.】

Liang Shi: 【...】

Single since birth and having acted in very few romantic scenes, Liang Shi was now completely stumped.

Her passive-aggressive skills couldn't match Xu Qingzhu's.

Clearly, she was also better at online chatting than Xu Qingzhu.

Obviously, she was quite proper in reality.

How did she become like this online...

Liang Shi sent her: 【Keep this up and I'll come upstairs to snatch your phone.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【... Teacher Liang, you can't take a joke.】

Liang Shi: 【Yes, I'm old, can't take jokes.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【?】

Liang Shi: 【Go to bed early.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Alright, no more joking, sleep well, good night.】

But Liang Shi suddenly sat up two minutes after turning off her phone, rapidly tapping the screen: 【You use my photo as your chat background, so in exchange, shouldn't you give me one of your photos?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【... What for?】

Liang Shi: 【Fairness.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Stunned.jpg】

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sent her a white background one-inch ID photo⁵.

Liang Shi: 【.....】

Xu Qingzhu was still the most ruthless.

Footnotes: ¹ Peace charm: Traditional Chinese amulets believed to bring protection and good luck
² Nine-grid: A popular social media format where multiple photos are arranged in a 3x3 grid ³
Weibo: Chinese social media platform similar to Twitter ⁴ Liang He vs Liang Shi: A play on Chinese
characters where the names sound similar but are written differently ⁵ One-inch ID photo:
Standard format for official identification photos in China, typically very plain and formal

Chapter 45-7

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The system had learned from the evening's events and waited until Liang Shi was about to go to sleep before giving her today's task report.

After switching systems, the voice sounded much better, though the mechanical sentence breaks were even more ridiculous than before, breaking so mechanically that it tired Liang Shi out.

【Ding dong! Congratulations to the host, your luck value has accumulated over sixty, triggering the passive task: Go to a concert with Xu Qingzhu. Current luck value is sixty-five, bad luck value is zero.】

【The passive task deadline is next Sunday at 24:00. The host can choose to give up one day early without deducting luck value. If the task is not completed by the deadline, three luck points will be deducted.】

【This task difficulty: Easy. Task reward is zero luck value, 29,999 yuan. Please work hard to complete the task, host! Ding dong, system offline.】

The new system was much less talkative, just delivered the task and left.

Unlike the previous one that often imitated humans, but when things quieted down, it actually felt a bit lonely.

Liang Shi felt she must be crazy.

Systems should be cold and ruthless. The previous system must have had a chip implant error.

Let it get properly reformed!

However, the passive task was to see a concert. Liang Shi searched on her app and found there weren't many concerts in Haicheng City recently.

But coincidentally, there was one this Saturday at the Haicheng City Concert Hall.

Liang Shi directly booked two tickets.

From now on, she would definitely complete passive tasks in advance and never give the system a chance to deduct points from her.

Just kidding.

She only needed thirty-five more points to regain her freedom.

Although her relationship with the Liang family wasn't great now, and there were still many mysteries in her life.

But she had Zhao Ying's help, and her acting career was going smoothly.

In other words, she no longer needed the Liang family as a stepping stone.

As long as she restrained her curiosity, didn't investigate those secrets buried in time, didn't worry about her lost memories, and became someone who went with the flow, she could definitely live a prosperous life in this world after her body came to it.

Liang Shi felt the future was promising.

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Meanwhile, in another room, Xu Qingzhu stayed up until two in the morning.

She looked at her chat history with Liang Shi, then forwarded it to Zhao Xuning.

Then chickened out and retracted it.

By the time Zhao Xuning saw it, it was just a bunch of retracted messages.

Zhao Xuning: 【What are you doing?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【I think I'm in danger.】

Zhao Xuning: 【... Are you being stalked?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【No, I... seem to... have lost control of my curiosity and desire to share.】

Zhao Xuning: 【Fallen for Liang Shi?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【... I wouldn't say I like her, we just talked for a long time tonight.】

Zhao Xuning: 【So you believed her? Got moved?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【... How could that be?!】

Zhao Xuning: 【Then what are you doing in the middle of the night? Are you bored?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【...】

She was left speechless by Zhao Xuning's retort. After staring at the screen for a long time, she finally sent helplessly: 【This person is just too curious and interesting.】

Zhao Xuning: 【So I told you to get divorced while she's being reasonable now, even a fake divorce would work.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Wouldn't divorcing now be bad? Her family has a pile of problems, and if I divorce her right when things are looking up for me, it feels like burning bridges.】

Zhao Xuning: 【Depends whether you want conscience or freedom.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Given how she is now, I think not divorcing is better. Marriage doesn't matter to me anyway, and our current way of getting along is pretty good. So going through all that trouble again, remarrying, would be very painful.】

Zhao Xuning: 【...】

— 【Is it painful without her or painful to go through the trouble again?】

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment: 【Should be the latter. You know, I don't have that much energy to put into marriage anymore.】

Having suffered enough before, she wanted freedom going forward.

But in the Xu family, her family wouldn't give her this freedom. She had to be in a married state to ensure her freedom of action.

Zhao Xuning: 【Then keep it this way, the current Liang Shi is indeed not bad.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Yes. shrug.jpg】

Zhao Xuning: 【But have you considered what would happen if she changed back one day? If her other personality returned, what would you do?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【... Divorce.】

She gave this answer almost without hesitation.

Zhao Xuning didn't say anything more after that, just told Xu Qingzhu to think it through herself.

The reason Xu Qingzhu chatted with Zhao Xuning was because Zhao Xuning had an excellent sense of boundaries.

She wouldn't boss around from a friend's perspective, nor would she interfere too much.

Just like Cherry¹.

Mutual respect with proper give and take.

Xu Qingzhu lay in bed, staring at the ceiling for a long time.

Forget it, just go with the flow.

But before going to sleep, she found the video of Liang Shi trending before, and browsed the topic more, discovering someone had posted more detailed videos.

Though they were all just profile shots, considered behind-the-scenes footage.

After watching, probably due to the filter effect, she felt Liang Shi's acting was much better than Chen Liuying's.

Although there were still Chen Liuying fans in the comments saying this passerby was ugly.

So Xu Qingzhu replied with her own account: 【Maybe you're blind.】

Footnotes: ¹ Cherry: A character mentioned earlier in the story, presumably one of Xu Qingzhu's friends

Chapter 45-8

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Monday was a sunny day.

Haicheng City, which had been raining for several days, was sunny again, and the weather forecast announced the end of many days of continuous rain, welcoming rising temperatures.

Sunshine improved people's moods.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu got up on time to have breakfast in the morning. One was responsible for making breakfast, the other for cleaning up—division of labor, very harmonious.

Both tactfully avoided mentioning last night's events.

In the morning, Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu if she needed to be driven to work. Xu Qingzhu spun the keychain on her finger, "I'll drive myself."

Liang Shi didn't insist, but just before getting in the car, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said, "Congratulations, Liang Shi, on successfully getting the role."

Liang Shi was dazed, "Didn't we talk about it last night?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled, "Saying it in person is more sincere."

Liang Shi was amused and in a great mood, "Thank you, Teacher Xu. Do you have time this Saturday?"

"For what?" Xu Qingzhu didn't immediately agree, "It's not that day yet, don't know if I'll have to work overtime."

Liang Shi: "I'd like to invite you to a concert, to cultivate our temperament."

Then she added, "Mainly to cultivate mine."

—Actually, it was to complete the task.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a few seconds, "We'll see when the time comes. I should be available."

Liang Shi didn't push her: "No problem, we'll talk about it then."

The cars left the villa one after the other.

Meanwhile, at the Liang family's old mansion.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had both gone to work, and Sun Meirou had taken Ling Dang to school.

Liang Zu was about to go out for business talks and was still at home watching the news. Qiu Zimin hesitated several times, wanting to speak.

Liang Zu noticed her strange behavior and looked at her several times, but she didn't speak.

When Liang Zu was about to leave, Qiu Zimin finally called out to him, "Honey, wait."

"What is it?" Liang Zu asked.

Qiu Zimin sighed heavily, "Let's go upstairs to talk."

Liang Zu raised his hand to check his watch, "Make it brief."

After returning to their room, Qiu Zimin carefully closed the door, then said carefully, "Master Yunyin¹ contacted me."

"What about?" Liang Zu frowned.

"He said Liang Shi's fate pattern has changed now. The original formation can't suppress her anymore, so it's starting to backfire on the Liang family. Think about it—wasn't the loss of that southern district land because of her?" Qiu Zimin said.

Liang Zu asked, "So what should we do? Remove the formation?"

Qiu Zimin nodded, "She's just a useless pawn to us now. Her fate pattern can't help Dongheng anymore. After removing the formation..."

She didn't finish the sentence, but Liang Zu said, "But we still have to support her. After all, she's publicly the Liang family's daughter."

"But we've been supporting her all these years, always cleaning up after her." Qiu Zimin suddenly choked up, "Our own daughter is still wandering somewhere unknown, yet we have to raise someone else's child."

"Her fate pattern did help the Liang family prosper for a while." Liang Zu patted her shoulder consolingly, "If it were our own daughter, we certainly wouldn't bear to give her up. Just consider it a transaction of interests. Besides, haven't we been looking for our daughter all these years? If we can't find her, what can we do?"

Qiu Zimin sniffled, "A few days ago, Dongling City cracked down on a human trafficking ring. Many children were reunited with their families. Watching the news always makes me think of our third daughter². If she were still at home, how wonderful that would be.

"All these years, I've just felt I owe our daughter. Having an unrelated girl in our house, with Xinzhou and Xinhe doting on her so much—if our daughter were here, she would definitely be loved and spoiled by her two brothers. Now, who knows in what remote place she's suffering."

Liang Zu sighed, "It's all my fault for not watching her carefully back then."

"Don't say that." Qiu Zimin immediately said, "When bad people want to commit crimes, what can we do? If we're talking blame, I'm also responsible for not taking good care of our daughter."

"About Liang Shi..." Liang Zu frowned, "If it's not too harmful, let's keep supporting her. Even if we really find our daughter, we can't just throw her out—what would that make the Liang family?"

But Qiu Zimin shook her head, "That's not possible."

Liang Zu was puzzled, "What's wrong?"

Qiu Zimin bit her lip, looking troubled, then sighed heavily with an expression of reluctance but necessity, "Master Yunyin said that now that Liang Shi's fate pattern has changed, if she continues to stay in our home, our family will suffer backlash. Look what she's become now."

"Her personality has improved a lot." Liang Zu said, "Her abilities are also stronger than before. Xinhe says she's performing very well at the company—she's promising material."

"Exactly." Qiu Zimin said, "Her fate pattern conflicts with our family's. After she improved, our family will surely decline from prosperity. What's the point of keeping her? Business is already difficult now. If we continue to keep her..."

Liang Zu also became anxious, "What will happen?"

Qiu Zimin shook her head, "Master Yunyin said it will inevitably cause endless trouble."

Liang Zu took a sharp breath, "That's not acceptable! The family business my father built with his own hands must not be ruined in mine."

Qiu Zimin's eyes filled with tears, saying helplessly, "Although she's not my child, I raised her with my own hands. Everyone knows I love this child the most. Now, like this, I can't bear it either. Moreover, Master Yunyin said we can't quietly send her away, or there will still be backlash. We must completely cut ties with her and can't provide any help."

Liang Zu was troubled, "That's too..."

"There's no choice." Qiu Zimin sighed, "Who told her that her fate pattern conflicts with our family's?"

Seeing Liang Zu still hesitating, Qiu Zimin continued, "But this is good too. If heaven blesses us one day and our little girl³ comes back, knowing that during her absence we were loving someone else, she would definitely be heartbroken."

Liang Zu was convinced. He closed his eyes, "Then we have no choice."

Then he asked, "What about those things in Liang Shi's room..."

Qiu Zimin said, "Don't worry. Following the master's guidance, I had them disposed of early and had her room repainted. There's definitely no trace left. This kind of thing can't be known by others—I understand."

Liang Zu nodded, "Right. The Lin family somehow got wind of something. A few days ago, Old Lin even asked me if we had replaced Liang Shi's soul. I was startled and deflected."

Qiu Zimin comforted him, "No one will know. Even if they knew, no one would believe it. Besides, it was just changing a fate pattern—where's the soul replacement? Pure nonsense."

Liang Zu: "Speaking of which, Liang Shi's fate pattern is really strong. Even after becoming like that, she could recover to her current state. To tell you the truth, when she looked at me during dinner last time, I kept thinking of when she was little—such a well-behaved and beautiful little girl, didn't talk much, but her eyes had spirit."

Liang Zu spoke with a nostalgic tone. Qiu Zimin immediately said, "Ah, if our little girl were here, she would definitely be like that too. Wonder how our little girl has been doing all these years."

Liang Zu thought of his third daughter who had been missing for years and sighed helplessly, "Yes, I also wonder how our little girl is doing."

After chatting for a while longer, Liang Zu asked, "So how should we cut ties with Liang Shi? If something like this suddenly happens, I'm afraid it will harm Dongheng."

Qiu Zimin smiled confidently, "The master has pointed out a clear path for this."

She whispered the method in his ear. After hearing it, Liang Zu couldn't help but admire, "Truly worthy of being a master—really brilliant!"

Qiu Zimin smiled gently, but finally felt relieved inside.

What to do with disobedient children?

Abandon them, of course.

She wanted to see what would become of Liang Shi without the Liang family's support.

Did she really think she had grown up and could spread her wings?

Heh.

Still too naive.

Footnotes: ¹ Master Yunyin: A Taoist master/fortune teller that the Liang family consults, literally means "Cloud Hidden" ² Third daughter: In Chinese families, children are often referred to by birth order. The "third daughter" refers to their biological daughter who was kidnapped ³ Little girl: An affectionate term for their missing daughter

Chapter 45-9

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Liang Shi was still unaware of all this and was diligently going to work.

After starting work, she shared the good news of her successful audition with Li Ran and the others.

Zhou Li treated them to bubble tea¹ at noon. Although she didn't say what it was for, Liang Shi secretly asked her, "Sister Li, is this to celebrate me getting the role?"

Zhou Li glanced at her, "How narcissistic."

But she didn't deny it.

Liang Shi had found her place in the workplace. She had strong adaptability and was now thriving like a fish in water.

She had also been observing all morning. Since both the system and that Taoist master said she would have a bloody disaster², she paid attention.

But she belatedly realized that she had already been inexplicably punished by the system that day.

Such severe heart pain—wouldn't that count as a bloody disaster?

It certainly would.

So she relaxed her guard.

Little did she know, she had relaxed too early.

But Monday was when tasks were relatively light, so Liang Shi contacted Qi Jiao in the afternoon, saying she wanted to meet with her.

Qi Jiao didn't reply to her message.

Having no choice, Liang Shi could only go to the kindergarten to intercept her.

After finishing her work, she proactively approached Zhou Li, "Team leader, let me help you pick up Rainbow."

"The teachers will help watch them." Zhou Li said, "No need to trouble yourself."

"It's no trouble." Liang Shi coughed quietly, "I have something to discuss with their teacher."

Zhou Li: "..."

Everyone turned a blind eye to Liang Shi leaving before work hours ended.

When she arrived at the kindergarten entrance, the large crowd of parents picking up students had already left, and there was a cool blue sports car parked at the school gate.

In the driver's seat sat a glamorous beauty with brown wavy hair, wearing sunglasses, completely out of place with the kindergarten atmosphere.

Liang Shi glanced casually and met her gaze.

Then she spoke her name: "Cheng Ran."

Obviously, Cheng Ran had seen her too.

She just didn't get out of the car and looked like she didn't want to chat with her.

But before long, Liang Shi saw Qi Jiao running out. She was about to go intercept her, but saw Qi Jiao running toward that blue sports car.

Liang Shi: "..."

Was Cheng Ran also involved in that incident?

Footnotes: ¹ Bubble tea: A Taiwanese tea-based drink with tapioca pearls, very popular across Asia

² Bloody disaster: In Chinese fortune-telling and feng shui, this refers to predicted misfortune involving injury, accidents, or bloodshed